ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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AI Tools for Studying: Use Them Without Cheating Yourself

Where AI genuinely helps learning, and where it quietly damages your degree

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

AI tools are useful tutors and dangerous shortcuts. This pack explains what they do well, where they confidently produce wrong answers, how to write prompts that produce checkable output, and how to stay within your department's integrity rules.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Use AI for explanation, practice and feedback rather than submission.
- Write prompts that specify context, level and output format.
- Verify AI output against reliable sources and detect fabricated references.
- Apply your department's rules on disclosure and permitted use.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What AI is good at

Treat AI as an explainer and practice partner, not an author.

- Re-explaining a concept at a simpler level until you understand it.
- Generating practice questions on a topic you specify.
- Critiquing your own draft for structure and clarity.
- Producing examples and analogies you then verify.
- Summarising a document you already have, as a first pass only.
- Translating and checking grammar in your own writing.

What it gets wrong

Language models produce plausible text, not verified truth.

- Fabricated references, statistics and quotations.
- Confident errors in calculations and niche local detail.
- Outdated information on current events, policies and prices.
- Bias and oversimplification on contested topics.
- Generic writing that sounds like nobody in particular.
- Hidden errors when you lack the knowledge to check the answer.

> **The verification rule**
> If you cannot check a claim yourself, do not submit it. A citation you have not opened is not a source.

Prompting and integrity

Better prompts produce more checkable answers.

- State your level, the course, the length and the required format.
- Ask for step-by-step explanation rather than the final answer.
- Request sources, then verify each one independently.
- Ask it to identify weaknesses in your argument, not to write the argument.
- Disclose AI assistance where your department requires it.
- Never use AI where it is prohibited; an acknowledgement does not make a prohibited act allowed.

What these tools are good at, and what they are not

Language models generate plausible text by predicting what usually follows. That makes them useful for explaining a concept in simpler words, generating practice questions, suggesting structures, and checking your grammar. It also makes them capable of confident invention - fabricated citations, wrong dates, non-existent laws - which is why every factual claim must be verified.

The distinction that matters is between using a tool to think and using it to avoid thinking. Asking for an explanation of a concept you then test yourself on is study. Asking for an essay you submit as your own is misconduct, regardless of how much you edit it.

Assume your institution will detect and penalise undisclosed use. Disclosure rules vary, so read your department's policy and, when unsure, ask before submitting.

Uses that genuinely help

Explanation at a different level: ask for a simpler explanation, an analogy, or a counter-example. Then close the tool and write the explanation yourself; if you cannot, you have not learned it.